

Accounting Ontology: The Structural Layer Behind Reliable AI Assistance

● Product

● Accounting Firm

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THE QUESTION

Why does structure matter for AI that works with accounting knowledge?

THE SHORT ANSWER

An accounting ontology gives AI a shared structure of concepts, relationships and definitions, so retrieval, answers and review work on meaning rather than on matching words. It is designed to improve accuracy, consistency and reviewability, and only stays valuable if it is owned, sourced, versioned and tested.

FOUR KEY IDEAS

1 Words are not meanings

Terms like period, entity and revenue change with framework, jurisdiction and context. Plain text matching finds words, and misses or confuses meaning.

2 Structure has several layers

Concepts, relationships, definitions, mappings and constraints. A glossary or taxonomy alone cannot express exceptions, applicability or supersession.

3 It changes retrieval and review

Disambiguation, expansion, filtering and traversal improve what is found. Named concepts and relationships make the basis of an answer visible to a reviewer.

4 Governance keeps it true

Owned, sourced, versioned and tested. An unreviewed ontology becomes another source of confident error.

WHO SHOULD READ THE FULL PAPER

Product and technical leaders, accounting firm leaders and knowledge professionals who need AI assistance to work on meaning rather than on matching words.

INSIDE THE FULL PAPER

What the full paper covers

#	SECTION	WHAT IT ANSWERS
1	The problem: one word, many meanings	Accounting language looks precise and is often not.
2	What an accounting ontology is	A more structured kind of knowledge than a glossary, and a more explicit one than a search index.
3	What an accounting ontology contains	Five kinds of content, each of which can be inspected.
4	How structure improves retrieval	Structure is designed to improve retrieval accuracy by helping the system understand what the question is about and what applies.
5	How structure improves consistency and reviewability	Two further benefits matter to professional firms as much as accuracy.
6	Building and governing an ontology	An ontology is a living asset. Left unowned, it ages into a source of confident error.
7	Evaluating ontology-backed AI	A vendor's claim of structure should be tested on your own terminology and questions.

QUESTIONS THIS PAPER HELPS YOU ASK

☐	Which concepts are modelled, and who owns them?
☐	Are relationships like "applies in" and "supersedes" represented, or only similarity?
☐	Is each definition linked to a source, version and effective date?
☐	Can a reviewer see which concepts shaped an answer?
☐	How are changes proposed, reviewed, tested and retired?

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